Resistance and ideological vacillation

However, as we conclude in the last pages, the contradictions that characterise all the BRICS have created incisive forms of social resistance. These include some of the largest protests and other social convulsions in the world, though some have expressed a conservative bias (Brazil) or articulated liberal ideals (India, Russia and Hong Kong). But other resistance struggles against mega-projects are manifestations of the limits to the BRICS' pro-corporate economic growth model. Most progressive activists mistrust the rhetoric of the BRICS governments, which promise prosperity for their countries by following the current trajectory of global neoliberalism, especially in alliance with one another.

Other radical activists and Third Worldist analysts have supported the BRICS governments, though, believing that their claims of wanting to democratise the world order might do more than simply add a layer of collaborators. There is not yet a consistent approach on the left, as progressive forces in each country operate still unaware of possible concrete links with other movements in the other BRICS countries, and even in their own hinterlands which BRICS corporations are busy exploiting. The critical question for the future is whether social struggles in each of the BRICS countries will discover linkages of solidarity between peoples, on the basis of reversing the path of the elites and creating paths for another kind of development.

This connection between the struggles and collective experiences of resistance and construction of alternatives is what we call 'BRICS from below'. Considering the various stances taken towards BRICS using a class analysis, we can discern some rough ideological positions towards this bloc of countries: 'BRICS from above' (the position of government and corporate bodies), 'Brics from the middle' (the position of some academics, think tanks and NGOs), 'BRICS from below' (grassroots social movements that can create common bonds of struggle and transnational solidarity), and, finally, those looking at BRICS from a pro-Western corporate perspective. The latter are adherents of the old capitalist order based on US hegemony, and fear the rise of the BRICS. We describe these positions, with three nuanced perspectives in the main categories, within the box below, based especially on experiences in South Africa.

From this attempt to organise ideological positioning, it is possible to identify various analyses of this group of countries. Recall that the first appearance of the acronym BRIC was in 2001, offered by Jim O'Neill of Goldman Sachs to identify promising markets for financial investors. There were those who discredited the bloc as an incoherent collection, arguing that these countries have nothing in common with each other. Others have considered these countries as a possible